

Arise, You Brave Picards!

Charles the Bold, Duke of Burgundy was killed on 5 January 1477 by Lorrainer and Swiss troops in the Battle of Nancy. Contesting the succession of Charles's daughter Mary to the Burgundian domains, Louis XI of France invaded both the ducal-comital heartland and the northern region of Picardy. Quickly wedding Maximilian of Habsburg—the heir of the Holy Roman Emperor and Archduke of Austria—for military and dynastic support in defense of her inheritance, Mary gave birth to Philip “the Handsome,” thus securing the succession, before tragically dying in a horse-riding accident in 1482.

Sometime during the French advance into Burgundy, Picard soldiers fighting under Maximilian composed the following chant:

Reveillez vous, Piccars, Piccars et Bourguignons,
Et trouvez la manière d'avoir de bons bastons,
Car veez cy le printemps et aussy la saison
Pour aller a la guerre donner des horions.

Tel parle de la guerre qui ne scet pas que c'est ;
Je vous jure mon ame que c'est ung piteux fait,
Et que maint homme d'armes et gentil compaignon
Y ont perdu la vie et robbe et chaperon.

Ou est ce duc d'Aultriche ? il est ou Pais Bas ;
Il est en basse Flandre avecques ses Piccars,
Qui nuyt et jour le prient qu'il les vueille mener
En la haulte Bourgoingne pour la luy conquerer.

Adieu, adieu Salins, Salins et Bezançon,
Et la ville de Beaulne la ou les bons vins sont ;
Les Piccarz les ont beuz, les Flamans les payeront
Quatre pastars la pinte, ou bien bastuz seront.

In the 20th century, certain regiments of the French Army with ties to Picardy adopted the song as part of their repertoire, albeit sometimes with the addition of four newly-written verses (in these versions, the original verses above are numbered 1, 2, 3 and 5).

On the following page, I provide my best attempt at an English translation that remains singable and preserves the rhyme scheme while capturing the essence of the meaning.

*Arise, you brave Picards! Burgundian faithful!
Now, find a way to battle our foe with blows painful!
For spring has come to us—with weapons in our hands,
It's time to go to war to guard our noble lands!*

*Some people talk of war but don't know what it is;
My heart and soul confess that it's all fear and all tears,
For countless men-at-arms—sons, husbands and fathers—
Fighting for law and love, have lost in it their lives.*

*This Habsburg prince our lord, the heir to Charles the Bold,
From Austria down to Flanders—Picard warriors, behold!
Pray and plead day and night that he'll soon lead us all
To Burgundy so that for its fate we may brawl!*

*Farewell, farewell, Salins! Salins and Besançon!
And fair town Beaune, with its wines that are second to none!
A hundred barrels gone; those rich Flemings will pay!
We're soldiers of your count; us you must not betray!*

A performance of the original text can be found at
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SjrGj6tYrN0>.

Source for the original text: *Chansons du XVe siècle publiées d'après le manuscrit de la Bibliothèque nationale de Paris*, ed. Gaston Paris and Auguste Gevaert (Paris: Firmin-Didot, 1875), 140-141.

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